



HORRIFIC: The victims

ment, could react, the stretch was littered with the dead and injured. Worse, rescue operations were hamstrung by the lack of an ambulance and the injured were ferried in public transport to the hospital at Anandpur Sahib, 16 km away.

Chief Minister Prem Kumar Dhumal has ordered a magisterial probe, and promised that such tragedies would not recur. The Naina Devi temple has seen tragedy before: a similar stampede in 1983 claimed 53 lives. Clearly, no lessons have been learnt. The Government has now set up a panel to study the Vaishno Devi Temple model for regulating the flow of devotees. But, if the past is an indicator, the authorities may soon forget the tragedy as a divine wrath instead of treating it as an administrative urgency.

by Ramesh Vinayak

Stairway to Death

SHIMLA Given the poor infrastructure and lack of a disaster management plan at most religious shrines in India, it was a tragedy only waiting to happen. On August 3, the first day of the Shravan Navratras, a stampede at the Naina

Devi temple killed 140 devotees. A 100-m-long column of more than 20,000 devotees was inching its way up the narrow path when a rumour about a landslide triggered a wave of panic. As those in the front began pushing

their way backward, a stampede followed. The side iron railings gave away as hundreds of devotees were trampled upon. By the time, the police, hopelessly in small number and without basic disaster control equip-

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

After appointing a "loyalist" as the new CBI director, the Government is short-listing candidates to head IB and RAW. Both posts fall vacant later this year and with elections looming, it is imperative that new incumbents swear by the family.

VOICES



"We might have lost our influence with the UPA Government. But then we have won the hearts of the Indians."

A.B. Bardhan, CPI general secretary

"If madrasas in Pakistan can create terrorist organisations like Jaish-e-Mohammad, then madrasas in India can also produce terrorists."

Pravin Togadia, VHP international general secretary

"The secular mainstream political parties support and propagate the agenda of fascist forces. The Jammu flare-up will plunge the state into a communal holocaust."

Mehbooba Mufti, People's Democratic Party president

"In our party, we take pride in maintenance of discipline. We don't have such situations normally. It is unfortunate that it had happened with a person of his stature."

Prakash Karat, CPI(M) general secretary on Speaker Somnath Chatterjee

"When I said we have to kick those in Karnataka opposing supply of water to Tamil Nadu, I was only referring to those who indulged in violence. Yes, I should have been more specific."

Rajnikanth, actor